

From Mercedes-Benz, BMW, Audi and Volvo to Porsche, Lamborghini and Jaguar Land Rover, most of the big luxury car brands are staying away, with only Lexus confirming its presence in the show.

In the ICE (internal combustion engine) two-wheeler segment, the interest is even lower. Patrons will miss five of the country's top two-wheeler makers—Hero MotoCorp, Honda Motorcycle & Scooter India (HMSI), Bajaj Auto, TVS Motor Company and Royal Enfield—at the expo. Coincidentally, these brands were absent in the previous edition hosted in 2020, too.

While the companies have not given any explanation for their lack of interest in the event of late, industry sources say multiple factors have affected their decision. According to a senior executive from a major two-wheeler maker, the timing and venue of the event have made it less attractive. “Given the harsh cold weather conditions in early January and the distant location of the event venue (from Delhi), we do not expect much returns on our investment,” he says.

Putting up a brave face is the country's top industry body for automobile makers and the organiser of the Auto Expo, Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM). According to Rajesh Menon, Director General of SIAM, participation of manufacturers varies from year to year. “In 2020, Toyota had skipped the event, but they are participating this time. So, there is no general trend that car manufacturers are moving away from Auto Expo. In the last edition, we had record footfalls at the venue of over 600,000,” he tells *BT*.

Menon is right. But it is also clear that the cancellation of the 2022 Auto Expo due to the pandemic has resulted in some companies not participating this time. “Companies prepare and plan for the Auto Expo over two years and line up their launches accordingly. However, as the expo had to be postponed for a year, many of the leading brands launched their

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SEVERAL MAJOR PASSENGER VEHICLE BRANDS ARE SKIPPING THE 2023 AUTO EXPO...

Who's in	Who's missing
Maruti Suzuki	Mahindra & Mahindra
Hyundai	Volkswagen
Tata Motors	Skoda
Toyota Kirloskar	Mercedes-Benz
MG Motor	BMW
Kia	Audi
Isuzu	Honda Cars
BYD	Volvo
	Nissan
	Renault
	Jeep
	JLR
	Porsche
	Lamborghini
	Citroen
	Force
	Mini

...AND SO ARE THEIR COUNTERPARTS IN THE TWO-WHEELER INDUSTRY

Who's in	Who's missing
Hero Eco Tech	Hero MotoCorp
LML Emotions	HMSI
Okinawa Autotech	Bajaj Auto
Liger Mobility	TVS
Tork Motors	Royal Enfield
MTA E-Mobility	KTM
Graviton Motors	Yamaha
	Kawasaki
	Triumph
	Ducati
	Suzuki

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planned models in 2022. This is a key factor behind them not participating this time,” an industry insider says on condition of anonymity.

At the same time, declining interest among two-wheeler buyers for ICE models may also have played a role in leading brands skipping the event since 2018. According to Menon, this time, vehicles sporting alternate fuel technologies will be a major attraction for auto enthusiasts. “This is a platform where the industry and enthusiasts will get to witness the new trends of the industry, especially in terms of different types of powertrains that are coming up. There is a lot of focus on pure electric vehicles and we have a host of such players participating this time,” he says. An ethanol pavilion is also being set up to showcase its usage as a reliable future fuel. Additionally, new alternate technologies such as hydrogen ICE would be in focus this time with manufacturers such as Suzuki and Yamaha showcasing their concept offerings, apart from CNG technology.

The showstopper at this year's Auto Expo will most certainly be Maruti Suzuki India Ltd (MSIL), the country's largest passenger car manufacturer, which is set to unveil its electric vehicle concept and a range of SUVs at its pavilion. It will display an array of 16 vehicles including an electric concept SUV, two new ICE SUVs, WagonR flex fuel prototype, and a customised range of existing products like Grand Vitara, XL6, Ciaz, Ertiga, Brezza, Baleno and Swift, among others. “Our showcases at Auto Expo '23 will highlight Maruti Suzuki's commitment towards cleaner, greener, sustainable and carbon-neutral offerings for tomorrow. We are confident that our range of all-new SUVs, futuristic concept EV, hybrid, flex-fuel prototype and products will capture the imagination of enthusiasts,” says Hisashi Takeuchi, Managing Director & CEO, MSIL. **BT**

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